MCI Winter School

The Consulting Profession – Myth & Reality

Innsbruck

24 February 2025

Introduction

Wolfgang Ritzberger
Partner | KPMG Advisory



Wolfgang is Partner in the Management Consulting practice of KPMG Advisory in Vienna. He has about 25 years of professional experience in consulting, specifically business and functional strategy development, business transformation, design and implementation of (digital) business and operational models, integration & separation, and Human Resource management. His main sectoral focus is Public, serving clients as the UN in Vienna, IGOs/NPOs, or Public Healthcare providers. He also worked 2 years at Borealis in Corporate Development. In addition to his consulting career he is lecturer for ESG and strategy (University of Vienna) and Change Management (UWK).

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Adela Roszkowski
Senior Manager | KPMG Advisory



Adela is also team member of the KPMG Management Consulting practice in Vienna, she is Senior Manager. Adela has a rather diverse background in philosophy and financial management, just recently she topped off her academic education with another Master, this one in Public Policy. Her main area of expertise is policy development and implementation, specifically related to ESG topics such as decarbonization, net-zero planning, or emission trading. Adela works both for IGO clients such as the UN, EU Commission, or the OSCE and for financial service institutions (mainly banks), helping the latter structuring their investment portfolio in compliance with regulatory requirements.

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Agenda

1.	Welcome and introduction	09:00 – 09:15
2.	Creating an understanding of the concept and the function of consulting	09:15 – 09:45
3.	What types of consulting exist	09:45 – 10:15
	Break	10:15 – 10:30
4.	The consulting process	10:30 – 12:00
5.	Consulting as a Profession	12:00 – 12:15
	Lunch break	12:15 – 13:30
5.	Cracking the Case	13:30 – 13:45
6.	Exercise incl. break (taken as needed)	13:45 – 15:45
7.	Q&A	15:45 – 16:30

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KPMG

Let us write the future together

Internationally connected and regionally represented at nine locations – as the largest auditing and consulting firm in Austria it is our claim to be a strong partner for companies.

With experience and know-how – our experts offer optimal solutions for complex challenges in the areas of advisory, audit, law and tax.



Building trust via expertise and action

KPMG Purpose kpmg.at/purpose

About KPMG



The company name consists of the founding members‘ initials:

Piet **K**lynveld, William Barclay **P**eat,
James **M**arwick and Reinhard **G**oerdeler

142 Countries

275.000 Employees worldwide

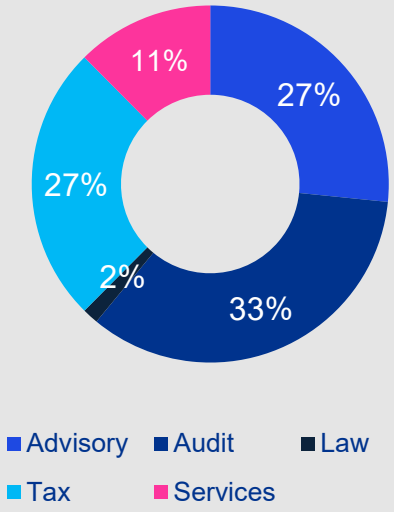
38,4 USD Billion Global Revenue

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About KPMG Austria

109 Partners

2.050 Employees

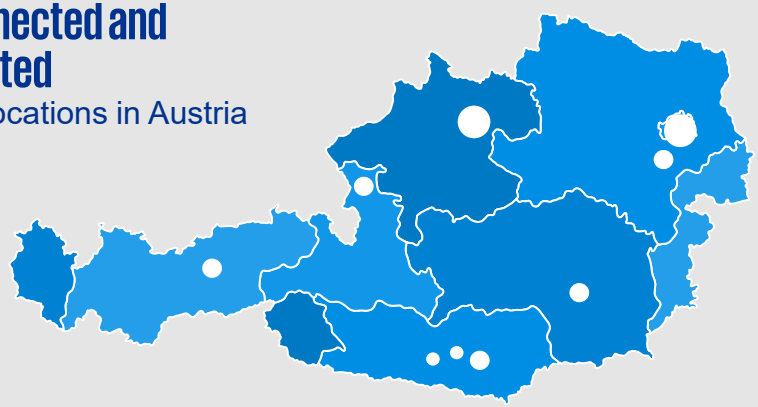


Revenue FY 2023/24

Total € 320,8 Million	113,4 Advisory	108,0 Audit	6,3 Law	93,1 Tax

Internationally connected and regionally represented

KPMG is active in 9 locations in Austria



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Functions – our Services

Advisory

With a focus on the areas of Deals & Strategy and Consulting, we develop industry-oriented solutions for our customers. We focus on topics such as Customer Experience, Operational Excellence, Finance & People, Risk Management & ESG, Technology Consulting and Cybersecurity.



Audit

Audit includes the review of annual and consolidated financial statements, sustainability information and other customer-specific confirmation services. Through independent and high-quality auditing, we strengthen the trust of investors, authorities, the public and other market participants in your corporate reporting.

Law

As a full-service law firm, we support our clients with all legal questions and represent them before authorities and courts. Our team consists of lawyers with specializations in different legal areas and extensive international experience. We accompany our clients in compliance with the highest quality standards and offer clear and efficient solutions.

Tax

Our team of excellently trained tax experts works together with our clients to develop innovative and practical solutions, including Corporate Tax and Tax Technology. In addition, we offer services such as accounting and payroll. Our tax optimization concepts are comprehensive and cross-border. They are based on professional expertise and many years of experience.

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Functions – our Services

ESG – Environmental, Social, Governance



Develop sustainable solutions together with our experts – for more innovation, profitability, and a higher company value.

Strategy

Professional support through specific activities up to a holistic company transformation

Governance & Risk

Master compliance and reporting requirements through effective governance and risk management strategies

IT & Technology

Technology as an enabler for building powerful professional systems in corporate management

Social Responsibility

Fulfillment of social criteria with diversity, inclusion and employee-oriented working conditions

Reporting & Key Figures

With knowledge of the new regulations and reporting standards for safety and transparency in everyday business

Value Chain

Opportunities through circular economy and responsible sustainable behavior along the entire supply chain

Processes

Expertise and know-how about sustainable procurement, financing, production, administration and sales

ESG services kpmg.at/esg

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Our KPMG-internal focus areas

At KPMG we not only focus on the optimal customer care through the ongoing optimization of our services but also on our internal development.



Sustainability

We take responsibility and support sustainability. For this, we have introduced numerous initiatives together with our employees – including **ESG training and presentations**, **e-charging stations**, **lease bike** offers and a **bee project** at our office in Linz.



Diversity

Inclusion and **diversity** have a high priority in our company. With several **focus groups** on the topic of diversity and external professional expertise, we focus on **equal opportunities** in the workplace and implement the results.



Digitalization

In order to be up to date for both our employees and customers, we deal with different topics of digitalization – from **AI and cybersecurity to cloud computing.** In addition, we work with a variety of **digital tools** to support daily work.



Further education

Know-how is our most important resource, for which **excellently trained employees** are the key. For this, we offer our employees a comprehensive training and further **education** program, which is **customized** to the individual requirements or business areas.

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Creating an understanding of the concept and the function of consulting

The Dilbert approach to defining "Consulting"...



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Now what is consulting really? Unfortunately, the term “Consulting” is not protected nor clearly defined in academic or business literature…

What can be found when googling Consulting…



Feng-Shui Consulting



Family Consulting



Job Consulting



Fashion Consulting



Food Consulting

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Today we talk about what is generally called "Management Consulting"

Management Consulting is defined here as a **professional service** provided by **one or more persons**, generally **professionally qualified** and **hierarchically independent** of the advised clients, for a **limited period of time** and **usually for a fee**, with the aim of defining, structuring and analysing **business management problems** of the client company **interactively with the client**, as well as developing solutions to problems and, if desired, planning their **implementation** together with representatives of the client and realising them in the company.

Management Consulting therefore involves providing support in dealing with business-related issues. Various aspects of the client company can be examined, such as strategic issues, organisation and business processes, information technology or personnel-related issues.



Consulting Research, Volker Nissen, Unternehmensberatung aus wissenschaftlicher Perspektive, Gabler Verlag | Springer Fachmedien Wiesbaden GmbH, Wiesbaden 2007

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Where did consulting originate? A short history of the profession

1st. The Need for Operations Efficiency in the Late 19th & Early 20th Century
Work rationalization; Arthur D. Little (1886) leveraged theories of Taylor and Babbage, who advocated specialization.

2nd. The Emergence of Management Consultancy
The boundaries of Management Consulting became clearer and more substantial as the service evolved.

3rd. Growth, Profitability, and Challenges During the 2nd Industrial Revolution
The second industrial revolution paved the way for expansion. Also, government started using consultants (BAH).

4th. Demand for Financial Advice Following the Great Depression of the 1920s
The Glass-Steagall Act (1933) stopped banks from getting involved in consulting. McKinsey, founded 1926, jumped in.

5th. Major Strategy Frameworks Created in the 1950s & 1960s
The BCG produced many strategy frameworks that are still in use today.

6th. The Emergence of IT Consulting And The Big Four
The need for consulting grew substantially in the 1980s and 1990s, mainly the demand for IT guidance and knowledge.

7th. The Business of Excellence
McKinsey was the first to establish the concept of “scaling up” success through excellence in the 1980s.

8th. The Segmentation and Specialization Era
Specialization by capability and industry sector is the most reasonable strategy and has been a major role in the expansion of management consulting into various specialties.



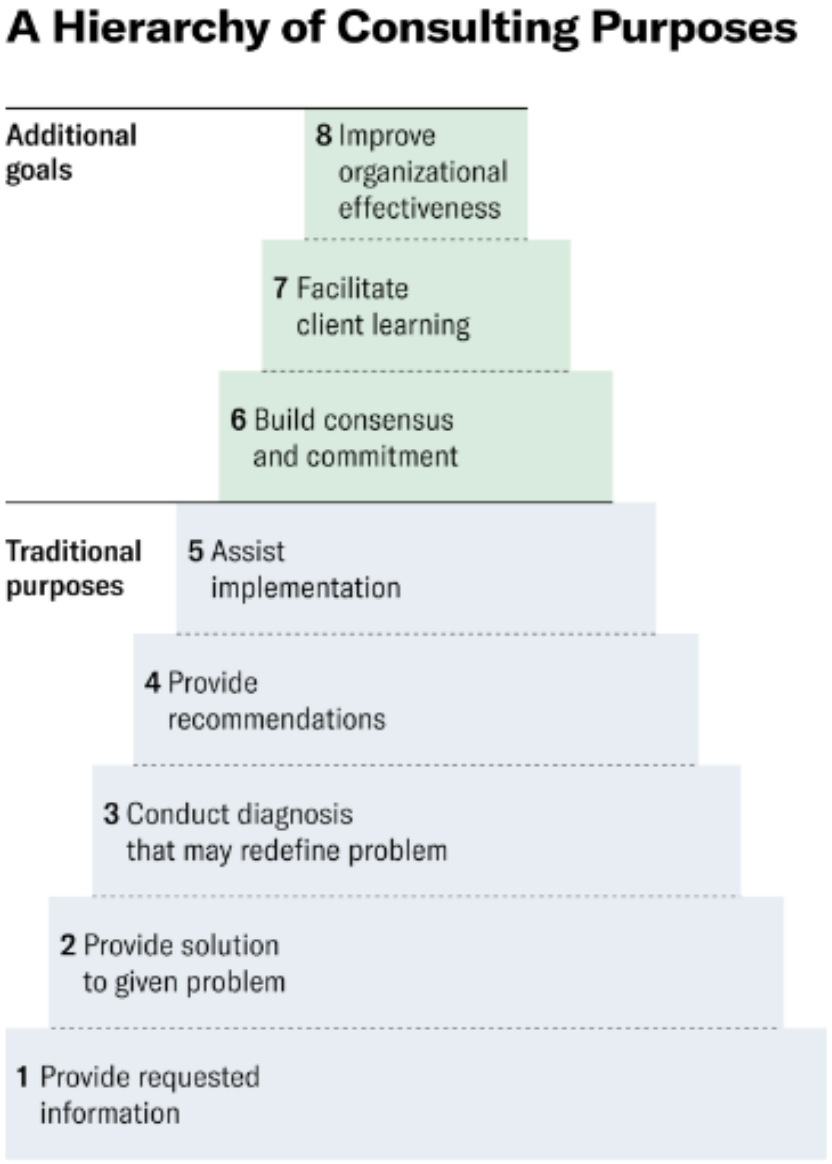
Consulting Quest; consultingquest.com/insights/8-stages-history-of-consulting

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What is the purpose of consulting

Consulting is the practice of providing expert advice and solutions to organizations or individuals facing specific challenges. Consulting entails specialized knowledge, skills, and experience in specific industries or domains that serve to help businesses solve specific problems.

The purpose of consulting is to offer objective insights, strategic recommendations, and practical assistance to help clients overcome obstacles, capitalize on opportunities, and enhance their overall performance. Consultants bring a fresh perspective and often employ a systematic and analytical approach to assess the client's situation, identify areas for improvement, and develop tailored strategies and action plans. Link



Leaders Link / Harvard Business Review Link

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Why do companies and organizations need consultants in the first place? Here's what consultants typically do (indicative examples)

"Only three things happen naturally in organizations: friction, confusion, and underperformance. Everything else requires leadership."

PETER DRUCKER

- **Analysis and Assessment:** Consultants analyze business operations, processes, strategies, and challenges by gathering data, conducting research, and performing diagnostic assessments.
- **Problem-Solving and Strategy Development:** Consultants identify problems, bottlenecks, and areas for improvement based on their analysis.
- **Process Improvement and Optimization:** Consultants work with the client's team to optimize business processes, streamline operations, and enhance efficiency.
- **Change Management:** Consultants guide clients through transitions by providing advice on communication, stakeholder engagement, and managing resistance.
- **Organizational Design and Restructuring:** Consultants assist in designing or restructuring organizational structures, roles, and responsibilities, proposing changes, and guiding implementation.
- **Strategic Planning and Execution:** Consultants help define strategic priorities, identify growth opportunities, conduct market analysis, and create implementation roadmaps.
- **Financial Analysis:** Consultants assess financial health, identify areas for improvement, and provide recommendations for maximizing profitability and managing financial risks.
- **Training and Skill Development:** Consultants deliver training programs in leadership development, project management, sales, or process improvement.
- **Performance Measurement and Evaluation:** Consultants establish performance metrics, evaluate performance, and help clients continuously improve.

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And here is what the market tells us – results of a study by Source





Source Global Research

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However, consultants do not always know the "correct" answer… here are some common misconceptions of consulting

- **Consultants have all the answers:** Contrary to popular belief, consultants are not expected to have all the answers to a client's problems. Their role is to provide expertise, insights, and recommendations based on their knowledge and experience.
- **Consultants are only needed for big companies:** While large corporations may frequently engage consultants, small and medium-sized businesses can also benefit from consulting services.
- **Consultants are expensive and only for high-budget projects:** While some consulting services can be costly, it's not always the case. The cost of consulting services varies depending on the scope, duration, and expertise required. Many consultants offer flexible options tailored to different budgets, including short-term engagements.
- **Consultants provide a one-size-fits-all solution:** Effective consultants understand that each client is unique and requires tailored solutions. They work closely with clients to understand their specific challenges, goals, and culture. They develop customized approaches that address the client's specific needs rather than applying a generic solution.
- **Becoming a consultant guarantees success and high income:** Transitioning into a consulting career does not guarantee instant success or a high income. Building a consulting practice takes time, effort, and a solid reputation. Success often depends on expertise, business development skills, networking, marketing, and providing "marketable" services.
- **Consultants primarily focus on giving advice:** While advice and recommendations are part of a consultant's role, they also engage in various other activities. These can include data analysis, conducting research, facilitating workshops, implementing strategies, training staff, and providing ongoing support to ensure successful outcomes.

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KPMG

What types of consulting exist

The term "consultant" can sound wide-reaching, but the services provided by a consultant are generally specific to their area of expertise

Here are exemplary types of consulting

- **Strategy Consultant:** Strategy Consultants operate at the highest consultancy level, focusing on corporate strategy, economic policy, government policy, and functional strategy. They typically work with top managers, mostly CxOs.
- **Management Consultant:** Also known as business consultants or organizational advisors, Management Consultants address various organizational concerns, from strategy to management elements.
- **Operations Consultant:** Operations Consultants help clients improve operational performance, offering advisory services and hands-on support for primary functions (e.g., Sales, Marketing, Production) and secondary functions (e.g., Finance, HR, Supply Chain, ICT, Legal). They form the largest advisory segment.
- **Financial Advisory Consultant:** Financial Advisors address financial and analytical capabilities within organizations. Their profiles vary widely, including M&A, corporate finance, risk management, tax, restructuring, real estate, and forensic research consultants.
- **Human Resource Consultant:** HR Consultants assist with human capital questions and HR department performance. Key topics include organizational changes, change management, terms of employment, learning & development, talent management, and retirement.
- **IT Consultant:** Technology Consultants, or IT/ICT/digital consultants, help clients develop and apply IT within their organizations, focusing on ICT transitions rather than day-to-day IT operations.
- **Marketing Consultant:** Marketing Consultants provide expertise in developing and implementing marketing strategies, including market research, brand development, advertising campaigns, digital marketing, social media strategies, content creation, and customer engagement.

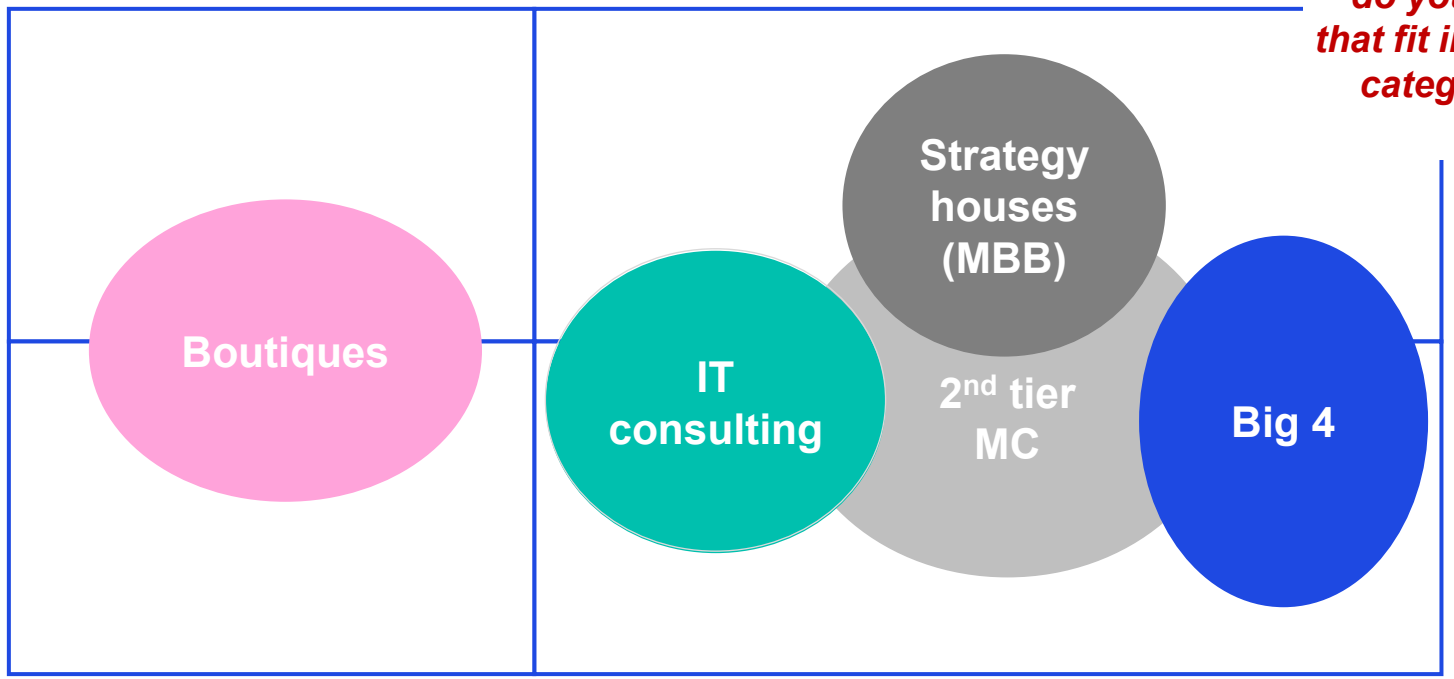
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There are several distinct types of consulting companies, this is one way to cluster and characterize them

Indicative positioning in the consulting value chain

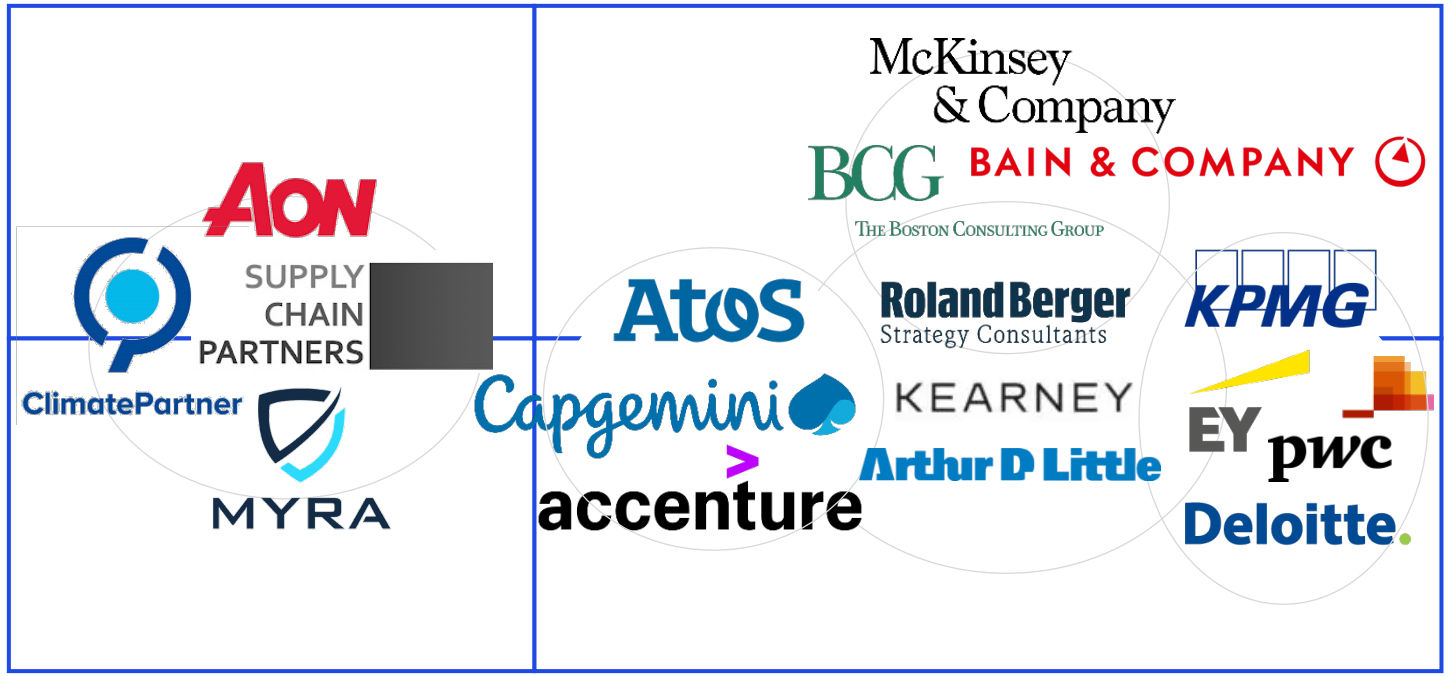
Your guess – what companies do you know that fit into these categories?



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There are several distinct types of consulting companies, this is one way to cluster and characterize them (examples)

Indicative positioning in the consulting value chain



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Especially the Big 4 have a comprehensive service portfolio, covering all stages from strategy to implementation – for example, the KPMG portfolio

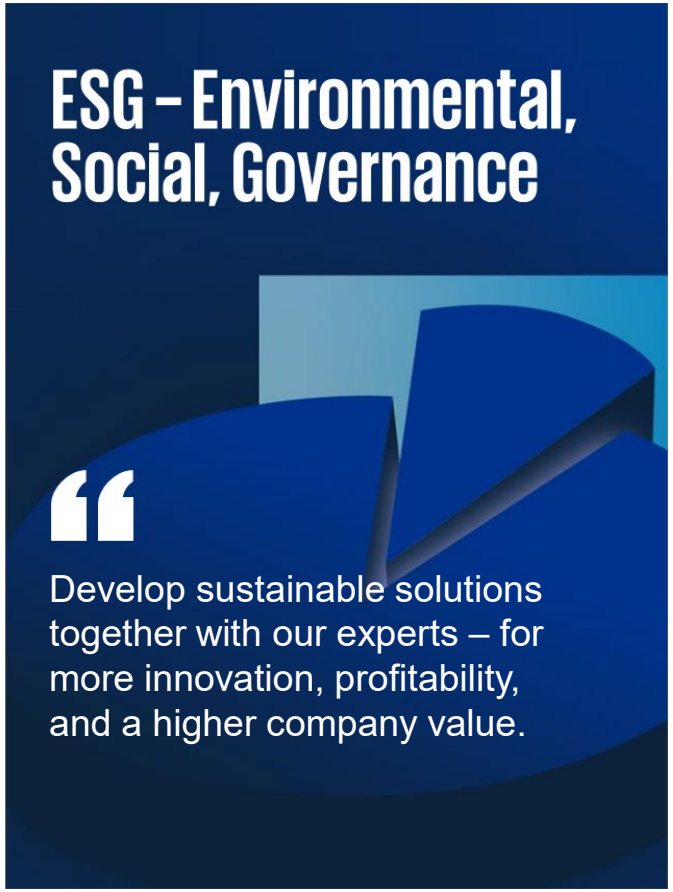
Our services include among others:

Deals & Strategy
- Mergers & Acquisitions
- Transaction Services
- Valuation, Restructuring, Finance
- Infrastructure & Real Estate
- Strategy, Integration & Separation

Consulting
- Customer & Operations
- Forensic, Internal Audit & Compliance
- Reporting Advisory Services
- Financial Risk Management
- Sustainability & ESG
- Finance & People
- Technology Consulting
- Cybersecurity

Lighthouse
- Development/Integration of new software





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The Management Consulting market in AT/ DACH… and globally, reaching a staggering 860 billion US dollars in 2022/3



The Management Consulting industry in Austria is valued at **€3.8 billion** and is ranked 12th in Europe in 2024. The consulting market is characterized by a mix of international consulting firms and local players. The market is driven by sectors such as financial services, manufacturing, and public sector consulting. Digital transformation, business model innovation, and regulatory compliance are some of the key areas of focus.



The Management Consulting industry has performed exceptionally well over the past years and remains on a growth trajectory, thanks to increased demand for consulting services because of the digital transformation. Industry revenue is evaluated at **€40 billion**. The profit margin of the industry is expected to be equivalent to 9-10%.



The market size of the global Management Consulting industry was **$860.3 billion in 2023**, having declined by 0,2% since the year before. The market size of the global industry has grown 1.0% per year on average between 2018 and 2023. Overall, the market size of the Global Management Consultants industry increased faster than the economy overall.

The DACH region, being one of the largest economies in Europe, has a robust consulting market. Germany contributes significantly to the consulting market. The consulting industry in the DACH region is diverse, with strong demand for services in areas such as management consulting, IT consulting, and strategy consulting. The region is home to several global consulting firms, as well as a large number of specialized local firms.

Globally, the consulting market is vast and diverse, with North America and Europe being the largest markets. The industry is characterized by a mix of large multinational firms and smaller specialized firms. In recent years, digital transformation, cybersecurity, and sustainability have emerged as key areas of focus in the global consulting market.

The COVID-19 pandemic has slowed down growth, but also created new opportunities, particularly in areas such as digital transformation, remote working, and crisis management. The market is expected to recover and continue growing, driven by the ongoing need for businesses to adapt and innovate in a rapidly changing environment.

Statista. IBIS World

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The biggest players in Germany

Top 20 der deutschen Managementberatungen
Sortiert nach Gesamtumsatz (Ranking)

2024	2023	Unternehmen mit Hauptsitz sowie der Mehrheit des Grund- und Stammkapitals in Deutschland	Gesamtumsatz in Mio. Euro 2023	Gesamtumsatz in Mio. Euro 2022	Mitarbeitende insgesamt 2023	Mitarbeitende insgesamt 2022
1	1	Roland Berger Holding GmbH & Co. KGaA, München	1.000,0	870,0	3.400	3.000
2	2	Simon-Kucher & Partners Strategy & Marketing Consultants GmbH, Bonn	540,5	534,9	2.017	1.953
3	5	Horváth AG, Stuttgart 1)	306,0	270,0	1.222	1.056
4	4	Porsche Consulting GmbH, Stuttgart	304,6	271,0	930	840
5	6	d-fine GmbH, Frankfurt am Main	266,2	221,6	1.572	1.215
6	8	zeb.rolfes.schierenbeck.associates GmbH, Münster	223,7	200,2	975	906
7	7	Detecon International GmbH, Köln	211,3	214,4	1.215	1.217
8	11	4flow SE, Berlin 2)	130,1	110,5	1.088	805
9	12	H&Z Group, München	127,0	99,7	637	592
10	14	Ingenics AG, Ulm	86,1	78,3	635	613
11	16	Cassini Consulting AG, Düsseldorf	81,9	73,8	431	412
12	15	Miebach Consulting Gruppe, Frankfurt am Main	78,0	75,0	460	440
13	17	Berylls Group GmbH, München 3)	72,0	62,0	232	157
14	17	Unity AG, Büren	71,6	62,0	380	380
15	20	Horn & Company Group GmbH, Düsseldorf 4)	71,2	41,9	235	123
16	19	Staufen.AG, Köngen	59,0	51,0	280	280
17	--	quattron holding GmbH, Bamberg	44,9	40,7	230	207
18	--	ROI-EFESO Management Consulting AG, München	39,0	37,8	149	138
19	--	Struktur Management Partner GmbH, Köln	37,3	28,0	99	89
20	--	Iskander Business Partner GmbH, Ismaning	29,8	29,4	59	41

Führende internationale Managementberatungen in Deutschland
Sortiert nach weltweiten Beratungsumsätzen (kein Ranking aufgrund der Heterogenität)

Unternehmen mit Hauptsitz sowie der Mehrheit des Grund- und Stammkapitals außerhalb Deutschlands	Beratungsumsätze weltweit in Mrd. Euro 2023	Beratungsumsätze weltweit in Mrd. US-Dollar 2023	Beratungsumsätze weltweit in Mrd. US-Dollar 2022	Mitarbeitende weltweit 2023	Mitarbeitende weltweit 2022
Deloitte 5) *)	32,1	34,7	31,1	163.000	145.700
Accenture 6) *)	31,1	33,6	34,1	162.000	160.000
PwC 5) 7)	20,9	22,6	20,7	117.090	105.960
EY 5) 7)	20,5	22,2	19,6	146.412	133.926
McKinsey & Company 7) *)	15,2	16,4	15,5	45.100	45.000
KPMG 5) *)	14,7	15,9	15,4	88.250	85.700
Boston Consulting Group 7)	11,4	12,3	11,7	32.000	30.000
Willis Towers Watson 7)	8,8	9,5	8,9	48.000	46.600
IBM 8) *)	8,5	9,2	8,8	49.900	48.000
Bain & Company *)	6,6	7,1	6,7	19.000	18.000
Mercer 7)	5,2	5,6	5,3	24.500	24.200
Oliver Wyman 7)	2,9	3,1	2,8	6.800	6.700
Ramboll	2,3	2,5	2,3	17.066	16.209
Capgemini Invent *)	2,2	2,4	2,1	13.200	12.000
AlixPartners 3) 7) *)	1,8	1,9	1,6	3.300	2.631
Kearney *)	1,8	1,9	1,7	5.187	4.604
Protiviti	1,8	1,9	2,0	5.900	5.700
Aon 9) *)	1,3	1,4	1,4	4.000	4.000
BearingPoint	1,0	1,1	0,9	5.969	5.173
Wavestone 1) 7) 10)	0,7	0,8	0,6	5.894	4.406

Lünendonk-Liste 2024

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Top Consulting Firms of 2024

McKinsey & Company

McKinsey is a company that needs no introduction. The company is consistently ranked #1 most valued brand in the industry, making it the most prestigious company on the list. Since its founding in 1926, the company has grown to +38,000 employees across more than 120 offices. The company generates $12.5bn in revenue annually.

McKinsey's recruiting process is one of the most competitive in the world. The firm typically hires candidates with Ivy League backgrounds and/or prestigious work histories. McKinsey is also known for pioneering the recruitment of advanced professionals with non-business degrees to its consulting teams. McKinsey consultants are known to be amongst the hardest workers in the industry, which in turn result in outstanding exit opportunities.

Annual Revenue: $12,500,000,000
Prestige: Highest
Employee Considerations: High turnover for young adults, great future career opportunities, long hours, constant travel

Boston Consulting Group

The Boston Consulting Group (BCG) is known as an innovative thought leader in the consulting industry with a strong focus on strategy. BCG has an intellectual culture that prioritizes creativity and academia. The firm has roughly 25,000 employees across 90 offices around the world. The company generates $11bn in revenues annually.

BCG is consistently ranked as one of the best places to work even while demanding long hours out of its consultants. The firm offers unique programs to its top performers, such as the Strategy Lab and BCG Fellows program. BCG also offers several programs and internships that focus on diversity, one of the firm's core values. Consultants who leave BCG are provided with top notch exit opportunities across almost any industry.

Annual Revenue: $11,000,000,000
Prestige: Highest
Employee Considerations: High turnover for great exit opportunities; ranked as top company to work for long hours, demanding culture

Bain & Co.

Bain is the youngest of the world's top three consulting firms. The company places a large emphasis on camaraderie and has the "frattiest" culture out of the MBB. Bain currently employs over 13,000 people across 50 offices worldwide.

Though "Bainees" build strong relationships amongst their teams, consultants are still required to work long hours in return for interesting projects and excellent exit opportunities. The firm utilizes a local staffing model, meaning that projects are as near each local office as possible. Bain has also differentiated itself through its expertise in private equity through Bain Capital, made even more famous by previous leader Mitt Romney. Bain has also earned a perfect score from the Human Rights Campaign for 12 years and was named 'Best Place to Work for LGBTQ Equality.'

Annual Revenue: $4,500,000,000
Prestige: Highest
Employee Considerations: Good benefits; ranked as top company to work for long hours, constant travel

managementconsulted.com/top-consulting-firms, update 2024

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KPMG

KPMG is well known as one of the Big 4 firms. The company has experienced massive growth in China and Hong Kong and generates roughly $35B in consulting revenue annually.

The main differentiator for KPMG is its work life balance. The firm offers great benefits, flexible hours, and a relatively mellow culture. KPMG consultants are known to be extremely supportive of one another and the firm places a high emphasis on feedback from supervisors.

Annual Revenue: $38,000,000,000
Prestige: Average to High
Employee Considerations: Good culture, good benefits, flexible hours

Ernst & Young

Ernst & Young's advisory business is known for services like those provided by other consulting firms. EY is headquartered in Boston, Massachusetts and generates $45B in annual revenue. The firm is ranked 7th in prestige amongst all consulting firms.

EY is known for having a significantly better work life balance compared to some of the other top consulting firms. The firm's is known to have good communication across hierarchical levels and most employees are known for collegial personalities. Bonuses and raises at the firm are performance based.

Annual Revenue: $45,000,000,000
Prestige: High
Employee Considerations: Performance-based bonuses and raises, good work-life balance

managementconsulted.com/top-consulting-firms, update 2024

Deloitte Consulting

Deloitte enjoys #1 market share in terms of revenue among Big 4 firms, generating $59B+ on an annual basis. The firm is consistently ranked as the fourth most prestigious consulting firm (after MBB) and has more than 415,000 professionals worldwide.

Consultants typically recruit for and advance their careers through one specific practice area. Deloitte's Strategy and Analytics arm – formerly Strategy and Operations – is essentially its management consulting arm, while its other practice areas have less to do with overall corporate strategy.

Annual Revenue: $59,000,000,000
Prestige: High
Employee Considerations: Upward mobilization, lower morale than at top 3, long hours, international travel

PwC Consulting

PwC provides a mix of industry and functional expertise to help clients address their most complex business issues and opportunities – from strategy through execution. PwC advises a significant number of the Fortune 500 and generates roughly $50B in annual revenue.

As standard with most of the top firms, hours tend to be long for consultants at PwC. Promotions don't happen as quickly at the firm compared to others, but PwC is a great place to start a career. PwC has numerous diversity groups and works with employees with disabilities.

Annual Revenue: $50,000,000,000
Prestige: High
Employee Considerations: Good place to start career, valuable work experience, frequent travel, long hours

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Roland Berger

RB is a strategy consulting firm headquartered in Munich, with 52 offices in 35 countries. Roland Berger operates as a generalist strategy consultancy and advises clients on management issues ranging from strategy development to performance improvement. Roland Berger also advises in the fields of restructuring and marketing, with a focus on the Automobile Industry.

The company employs roughly 2,400 consultants worldwide and generates roughly $670M in revenues annually. The firm is known for its European culture and roots and for having bonuses that contribute to a major portion of compensation for employees.

Annual Revenue: 670,000,000
Prestige: Average (High in Europe)
Employee Considerations: Major bonuses, good benefits, sabbaticals offered, telecommuting

Kearney

Kearney (formerly known as A.T. Kearney) is an American global management consulting firm that focuses on strategic and operational CEO-agenda issues facing businesses, governments and institutions. Kearney maintains offices in more than 40 countries globally. The company generates roughly $1.4B in consulting revenues every year.

The company is known for advocating strongly for female leaders, especially in countries such as India. Kearney offers several programs focused on diversity and inclusion.

Annual Revenue: $1,410,000,000.
Prestige: High
Employee Considerations: Good culture, well balanced

managementconsulted.com/top-consulting-firms, update 2024

AlixPartners

We've got two competitors coming up back-to-back. AlixPartners, founded in 1981, is one of the world's premier turnaround consulting firms. It has advised on some of the most famous Chapter 11 reorganizations in history, including Enron, GM, and Kmart.

The firm is known for its long work hours and meritorious culture, but compensation reflects this. If a fast-paced work culture and tight deadlines get your heart racing, as does bringing companies back from extinction, AlixPartners should be on your list of target firms.

Annual Revenue: $2,000,000,000
Prestige: Average to High
Employee Considerations: Front-line work with great client and partner exposure, work hard, play hard

Accenture

Accenture is a technology consulting firm with a strategy consulting arm. The firm's footprint is massive, with an estimated 700,000 employees across the world. Accenture is especially great for aspiring consultants who value opportunities to learn about technology.

Accenture is known to have a challenging work culture. Overtime is optional, but many consultants reportedly need to work the extra hours. In order to excel at Accenture, its consultants say networking is essential in order to land the best teams and projects.

Annual Revenue: $61,500,000,000
Prestige level: High
Key employee considerations: Optional overtime, good opportunities to learn about technology

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The consulting process

The consulting process typically follows basically the same structure, the number of steps varies between companies

1. Contract
2. Agreement
3. Information and assessment
4. Feedback
5. Seeking alignment
6. Change targets and transition strategies
7. Implementation
8. Evaluation and learning.

1. Understand Client
2. Analyse
3. Design
4. Planning
5. Execution
6. Transition
7. Support

Seven C's of Consulting (Mick Cope)

1. Client
2. Clarify
3. Create
4. Change
5. Confirm
6. Continue
7. Close

5 phases of consulting

1. Contact
2. Discussion
3. Negotiation
4. Implementation
5. Evaluation



McKinsey problem-solving process

1. Define the problems
2. Find the root cause
3. Use “hypothesis-driven” process
4. Analyze with “issue tree”
5. Propose solutions.

Google

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The consulting work has changed a lot since 1886 when a chemist, Arthur Dehon Little, founded the first (technical) consulting company

Here are examples for more recent approached we had to take up

1. Scenario Planning
- Scenario planning is a method to anticipate and prepare for different possible futures based on uncertainties affecting a client's situation.
- It helps identify opportunities and risks, design adaptable strategies, and effectively communicate findings to the client.

2. Design Thinking
- Design thinking is a method to understand a client's customers' needs and create desirable, feasible solutions.
- It aids in generating innovative ideas, testing them, and fostering creativity and alignment through collaboration.

3. Data Visualization
- Data visualization is a tool to present complex data in a clear, concise, and compelling way.
- It helps highlight key insights, patterns, and trends, and supports persuasive, data-driven arguments.

4. Digital Transformation Framework
- The digital transformation framework is a tool to assess and improve a client's digital maturity and capabilities.
- It helps identify gaps and opportunities in strategy, culture, processes, technology, and customer experience, and define actions to leverage digital technologies.

5. Systems Thinking
- Systems thinking is a method to understand and address complex and dynamic problems a client faces.
- It helps map out interrelationships and feedback loops and identify interventions that can create positive change in a client's system.

6. Agile Project Management
- Agile project management is a method to deliver value to clients faster, more efficiently, and flexibly.
- It helps break down projects into manageable tasks, adapt to changing requirements, and improve teamwork and collaboration.

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And of course, we use a huge number of fancy tools now…



AskBrian; askbrian.ai/blog/top-management-consulting-tools-2022

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Especially the arrival of agile methods revolutionized the consulting approach – not only in the IT sector

Agile principles

Customer focus



Always closely aligned with the customer to develop the MVP

Iterative work



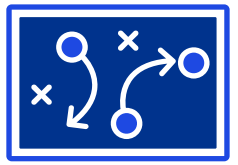
Risk-minimising trial-and-error approach and rapid prototyping

Cross-functional teams



Flexible and customised solutions to meet your challenges

Autonomous, aligned actions



Ensures that the work is always orientated towards the common goal

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The agile project approach can be varied but its logic remains constant



Daily Scrum
- Plan for Today
- Add Text Here

Sprint Review
- Demo features
- Add text here

Sprint Planning Meeting
- Sprint Goal
- Product Backlog Review

Backlog Tasks
Expanded by team

24 Hours

Sprint
1- 4 Weeks

Sprint Retrospective
- Adapt and Inspect

Vision

Product Backlog
Prioritized features desired by customer

Sprint Backlog
- Features mentioned with Sprint
- Team Estimation

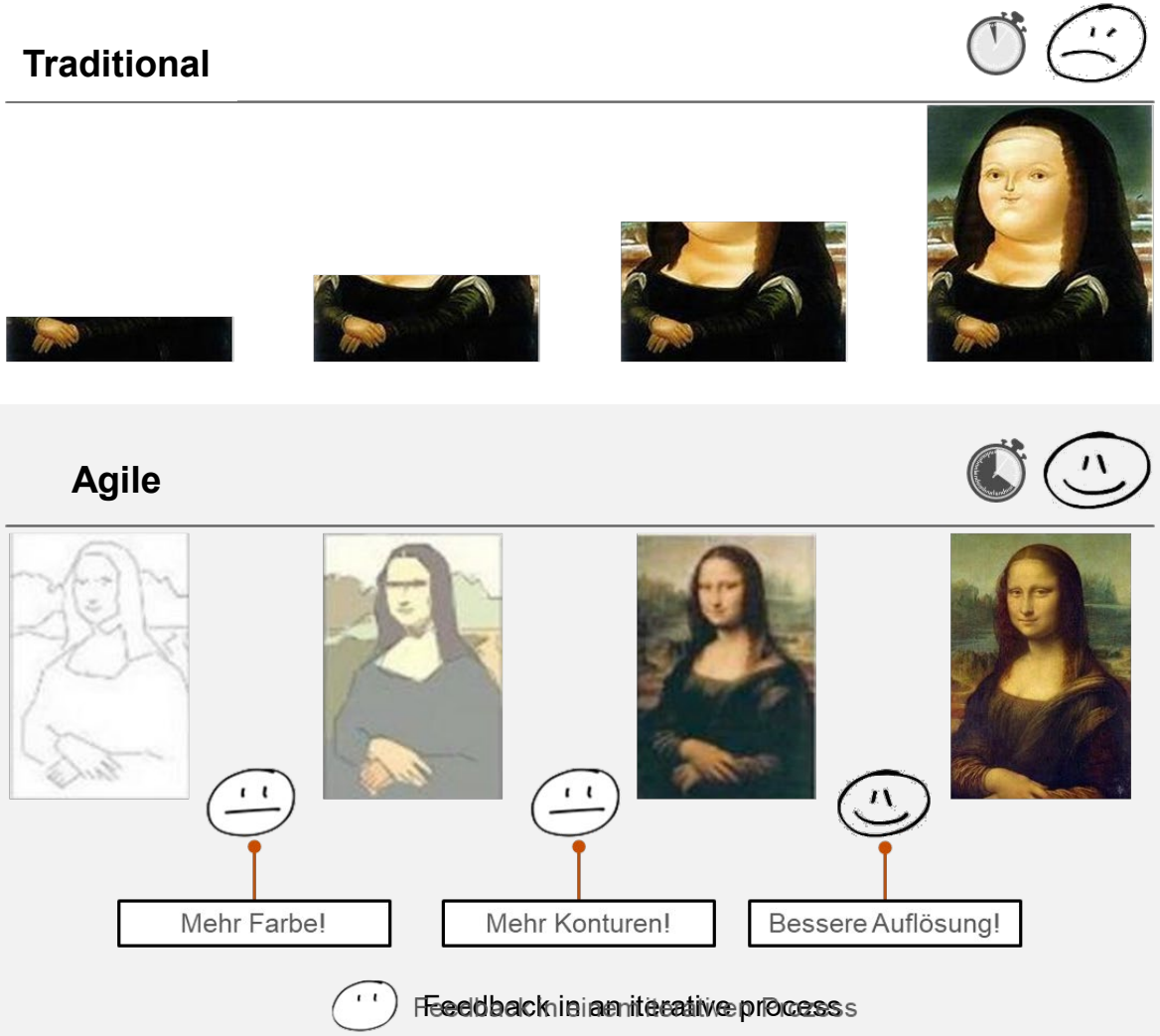
Potentially Shippable Product Increment

www.slidegeeks.com

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And that is the BCG explanation of agile...

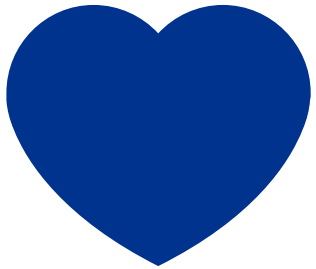
"Agile is a new way of working that enables an organization to be more nimble, more focused on value to customers, more attractive to talent, drive better outcomes and achieve faster time-to-market."



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Design Thinking – a creative methodology we apply in appropriate projects



Empathic

- Empathize with customers/users to thoroughly understand them
- Discover the life and context to get to know their motivations
- Postpone judgement to stay open to new insights



Optimistic

- Seeking opportunities, looking at what can be (not at what cannot be), build on each others' ideas
- Associate and get inspired by other industries/solutions/etc
- Diverging before converging, challenging assumptions

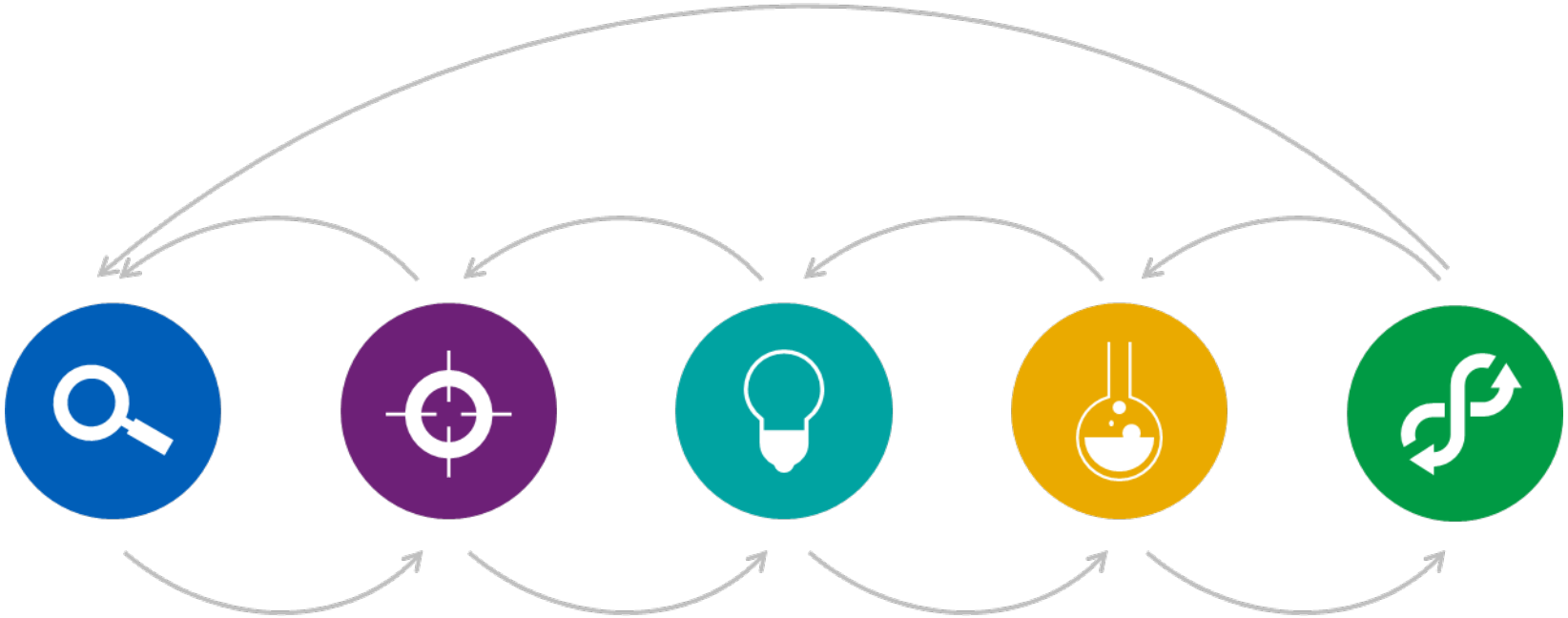


Experimental

- Build (3D) prototypes to test assumptions with customers/users
- Gain insights by experimenting in real life, learn by doing
- Use probes to provoke reactions and dig a little deeper

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The Design Thinking process follows a well established sequence of steps



DISCOVER

Conduct research to develop an understanding of your customer.

DEFINE

Conclude from your research what customers' problem is.

IDEATE

Generate a set of creative ideas solving the defined problem.

EXPERIMENT

Build real tangible prototypes to test your ideas with real customers

EVALUATE

Review your test results and the feasibility of the designed solution.

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Design Thinking – examples for tools & methods

DISCOVER	DEFINE	IDEATE	EXPERIMENT	EVALUATE
Interview (1-1)	Personas	Creative sessions	Paper prototyping	User testing (1-1)
Group interview	Storyboarding	Brain writing & drawing	Wireframing	Group testing
Questionnaires	Written Scenario's	Brainstorming	Design Drawing	A/B testing
Generative sessions	List of Requirements	H2 (how-tos) / HMW	3D models	Role-Playing
Observations (1-1)	Problem Statement	Analogies & Metaphors	Video Visualization	Feedback Sessions
A day in the life of	Touch point matrix	Absurd questioning	Storytelling/-boarding	Pilot
Photo Journal	Experience map	Guided fantasy	Service blueprint	
Collage / Draw it!	WWWWWH			
Image association				
Service Safari		***To evaluate ideas:***		
Mindmapping		Harris Profile		
Journey mapping		C-box (plot innovative and feasibility)		

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The consulting industry is facing a number of challenges that constantly change established processes

Exemplary change drivers

1. **Adapting to New Technologies:** Consultants need to stay up-to-date with the latest technologies and understand how they can be used to improve their clients' businesses.
2. **Data Security:** As consultants often have access to sensitive business information, ensuring data security is a major concern.
3. **Increased Competition:** Digitization has allowed new players to enter the marketplace, increasing competition for consulting firms.
4. **Value Demonstration:** With increased competition, consultants need to clearly demonstrate the value they bring to their clients, especially in the light of commoditization of consulting services and the need to specialize.
5. **Increased Client Expectations:** Client expectations are the top business pressure for consultants, with demands for faster responses, tighter timelines, and greater deliverables.
6. **Tighter Timelines:** Consultants are facing tighter timelines, from the initial contract to project deliverables. The selection process is condensed, and consultants must be ready to present their project concept quickly.
7. **Talent Acquisition and Retention:** With the increasing demand for specialized knowledge, finding and retaining top talent has become a challenge, most recently with the need to quickly build critical mass of ESG expertise.
8. **Remote Work**: The COVID-19 pandemic has led to a shift towards remote work, presenting challenges in terms of communication, collaboration, and project management.

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As an example, digitalization brought about a major shift in business context and the respective consulting approaches

Reorientation in consulting

How does „Consulting 4.0“ relate to the business context

Industrie 4.0		Consulting 4.0	
1.0	Industrialisation and steam engines	1.0	Operations efficiency
2.0	Electricity and assembly line	2.0	Growth, profitability, and financial advice
3.0	Electronics and information technology	3.0	IT consulting and implementation
4.0	Digitalisation and sustainability	4.0	Digital and ESG transformation

What does it mean for consulting

- **Digitalisation of consulting topics:** Taking up current trends and technological developments (IoT, web 2.0, Industry 4.0, Big Data, D&A, etc.) and making them usable for clients; primarily (strategic) business topics, but are often addressed from a technological perspective by IT consultants
- **Digitalisation of consulting processes:** Customer expectation that consulting firms will also increasingly digitalise their processes, if only for reasons of credibility

- **Digitalisation of consulting knowledge:** strategic decision between digital availability of distributed knowledge vs. reducing the depth of services and "outsourcing" knowledge processing
- **Digitalisation of consulting services:** involves the development and use of digital variants of established consulting services (such as virtual collaboration, which is also being massively promoted by COVID-19) or models such as software-as-a-service, eConsulting stores, etc.

Lippold, Grundlagen der Unternehmensberatung, 2019

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The challenges of the digital age are creating new tasks and business models in consulting – some examples

Digitalisation of consulting business models: digital platforms and networking enable the emergence of new business models that compete with "traditional" consulting, such as peer-to-peer consulting, freelance consulting, crowd consulting - all with significant consequences and pressure to change for established consultants.

Emerging consulting business models

Solution Centres and prototyping

Changing customer expectations

- Increasing technical complexity of requirements for consultants
- Customers attach great importance to active participation in the entire solution development process, from project conception to project implementation
- Prototypes (MVP) are used to present tangible proposals at an early stage

Consequence for consulting

- Involvement of innovation hubs, prototype design studios, etc.
- Cost and resource-intensive services
- Challenge for small consulting firms without a global network and expertise

Eco-systems and acquisitions

In-house resources vs. network

- Smaller consulting companies lack the resources to map expertise and tools
- Partnerships with external specialists offer favourable, flexible alternatives to in-house expertise
- Networks and partnerships are involved early in the acquisition phase as a USP
- Acquisition of expert consultancies to build up in-house expertise
- Platforms for specialists are used directly by customers,, consultants act as intermediaries – new role of “Network Manager”

Assets and managed services

Consulting Assets

- Focus on software solutions developed by consultants / co-operation partners
- Investments in expert resources for the development of customized solutions
- Software solutions are used repeatedly, core consulting business remains the same, supplemented by IT assets

Managed services

- Customers do not require in-house resources and expertise
- Tasks extend into increasingly complex technological areas and are particularly important in transformation processes

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The new way of consulting – KPMG Insight Centers

Insights Centers



The KPMG Insights Centers are high-tech collaborative environments, where we explore data, AI & emerging technologies, and the latest analytic solutions and services from the KPMG global network.

We bring complex data enabled technologies to life, and help organizations make finer — and faster decisions. Together with clients we discover, innovate and transform their business.

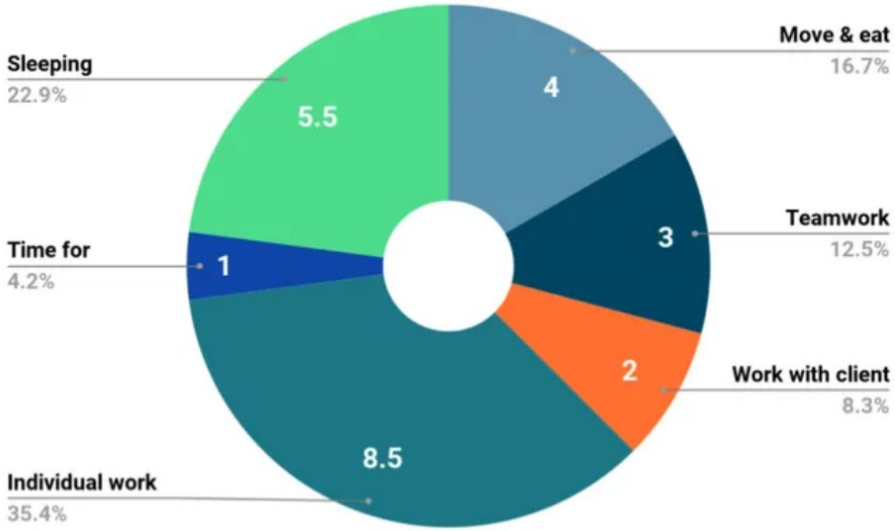
In the Insights Centers we help clients turn data into insights that lead to value.

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Consulting as a Profession

A Day in the Life of a Management Consultant



Morning routine

7:00 – 7:30: Make the most of the time along the way

8:00 – 8:30: Team meeting at the beginning of the day

8:30 – 9:00: Working with support team

9:15 – 11:00: Preparing materials for the afternoon interview

11:00: Arranging support team and wrap up work before lunch

12:00: Lunch time!

12:13: Rescheduling plan (unexpected events sometimes happen)

12:15: Skip the unfinished lunch to meet the deadline

Afternoon routine

13:30: Client meeting

14:30: Making calls to gather information

14:45: Handle consultant's daily work (data gathering, number crunching, email processing,.. anything on the to-do-list)

19:00: Internal team meeting to report our progress

Evening routine

Normal people's work stops at around 17:00 or 18:00, and there's absolutely no work in the evening. But hey, remember, you are living a life as a consultant.

After dinner, besides a little time for personal tasks, I still must complete a bunch of work like sending emails or feedback for tomorrow's work before going to bed.

19:30: Dinner time!

Team dinner! This is the precious time to network and know your team players better. On most dinners, we have about half of the team.

21:00: Relaxing and clearing personal tasks

21:30: Preparing for the next day's work

0:00: Bedtime (but not really). It really depends on how much work you have and how productive you are. We just try our best for some extra sleep because tomorrow will be another busy day.

MConsulting prep; mconsultingprep.com/day-in-life-of-consultant

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Work-life balance in consulting is difficult but possible (somehow)

Work-life balance in Consulting can vary greatly depending on the setting, specialization, and individual approach to their work. Here are some factors to consider:

1. Work Hours: Consultants often have the flexibility to set their own hours, which can be beneficial for work-life balance. However, they may also need to offer evening or weekend sessions to accommodate their clients' schedules.

2. Emotional Demands: Consulting is emotionally demanding work, which can impact work-life balance. Consultants often need to take steps to manage their own mental health and prevent burnout.

3. Caseload: The number of clients a consultant sees can greatly impact their work-life balance. A high caseload can lead to long hours and increased stress.

4. Setting: Consultants who work in private practice often have more control over their schedule and caseload than those who work in settings like hospitals or schools.

5. Self-Care: Consultants need to prioritize self-care to maintain a healthy work-life balance. This can include activities like exercise, meditation, hobbies, and spending time with loved ones.

6. Supervision and Support: Having access to supervision and support can help consultants manage the emotional demands of their work and maintain a better work-life balance.

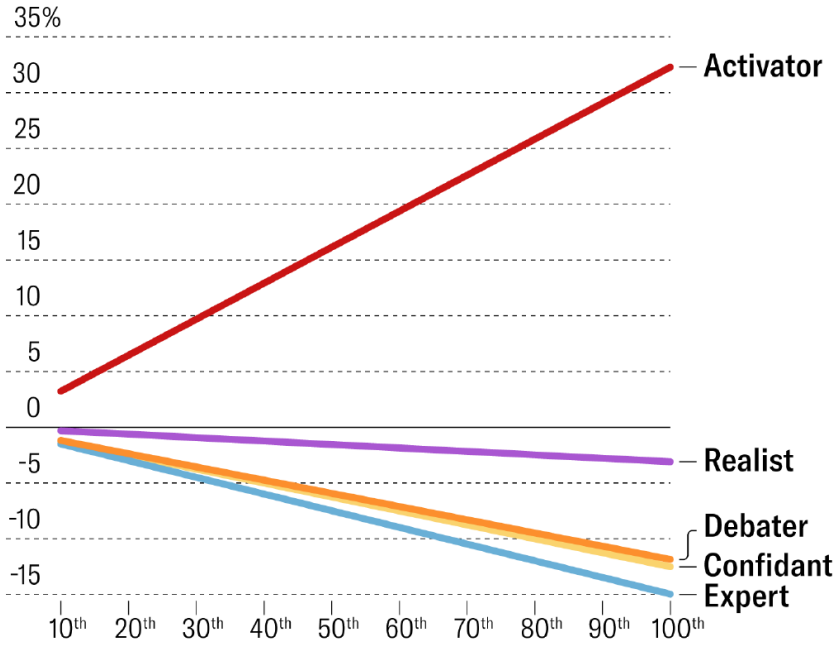
In general, achieving a healthy work-life balance in consulting requires setting boundaries, managing time effectively, and prioritizing self-care. It's also important for consultants to seek support when needed, whether from supervisors, colleagues, or their own therapists.

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It requires a certain mindset to become a successful Management consultant – and you might recognize yourself in one of the profiles

Performance impact
(referring to revenue generation)



Profile strength (based on the degree to which a person demonstrates the attributes associated with a given profile)

Activator
- Leverages events and social platforms to build a robust client network
- Educates clients on critical trends and issues
- Proactively engages clients on new opportunities to work together
- Introduces clients to other partners and practice areas

Realist
- Focuses on setting proper expectations with the client
- Openly discusses budgets, fees, and schedule issues with the client
- Is comfortable telling the customer no
- Deliberately avoids no-win situations

Debater
- Is very opinionated
- Loves to debate clients on what's best for their business
- Brings innovative solutions to the client
- Expects the client to agree with the plan of action

Confidant
- Is highly responsive to client needs and builds deep relationships
- Delivers exceptional service
- Leverages strong track record of client work to get new business
- Emphasizes senior-most relationships

Expert
- Responds to established demand instead of proactively creating demand
- Leads with deep subject-matter expertise that matches client needs
- Prioritizes clients with established budgets

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It requires a certain mindset to become a successful Management Consultant

- **Activators** are network builders. They spend a significant portion of their business-development time identifying and engaging with prospective clients through tools such as LinkedIn and at industry and firm-sponsored events. Activators focus on establishing relationships across client functions and up and down the org chart. Their business-development approach tends to be proactive. They “harvest” business from their network—for example, reaching out to current and prospective clients when changes occur in the regulatory or economic environment. They also look for opportunities to introduce their clients to partners from other practice areas in their firm who they think can provide value. In our regression and analysis, the professionals who most strongly exhibited the behaviors that typify the Activator pattern had the most positive impact on revenue.
- **Realists** pride themselves on their transparency and honesty with clients. In our survey of C-level buyers, only 10% of respondents said that their trust in partners and firms has increased over the past five years. In a market crowded with partners who overstate their experience and capabilities and frustrate clients with outsize invoices, Realists are completely transparent about what they can and can’t deliver, what services will cost, and what the client should realistically expect in terms of outcomes and value. As such, they aim to avoid putting themselves in “no win” situations—for example, engagements that are unlikely to produce their intended results or work that can’t be delivered on time or on budget. This approach is very effective in completing work that meets expectations, but Realists’ “glass half empty” attitude can be off-putting for clients who prefer an aspirational approach.
- **Debaters** are contrarians who have strong opinions about how projects should be executed and are unafraid to share them, often pushing clients outside their comfort zones. They believe they know best and expect clients to follow their lead. Curiously, this posture is one that we’ve found in previous work to be highly correlated with strong performance in B2B sales. However, the relative underperformance of Debaters in professional services suggests that while this profile may be effective when selling products like software, it falls short when the person doing the selling is the product. As one C-level client told us, “I want the partners I work with to push my thinking. But if every time we sit down I’m being told I’m ‘doing it wrong,’ it just becomes mentally exhausting.”
- **Confidants** are extremely client-centric, highly responsive, and focused on building a reputation for executing superior work. These partners rely on relationships with clients that date back to law school, business school, or previous jobs. Because of how much they’ve invested in building the relationships, they are quite protective of them internally. And having established a track record of excellent work, they expect clients to return to them automatically. Of all the partner profiles we identified, Confidants are closest to the classic “trusted adviser” model that is often held up as the gold standard in the industry.
- **Experts** are best described as reluctant business developers. They focus on burnishing their public reputations as deep subject-matter experts—often through publishing, speaking, thought leadership, and so on—and assume that clients will seek them out for their services. Their business development consists primarily of responding to inbound demand from clients whose needs match their skill set and who already have a budget set aside. Much of their work comes from requests for proposals and competitive pursuits or from providing expertise on other partners’ projects.

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Wanted consulting profiles...

1. Academic Success
2. Work Experience
3. Leadership and Initiative
4. Perfect Presentation
5. Consulting Fit
6. Commercial Awareness
7. A Natural Communicator
8. Self-awareness
9. Teamwork
10. Personality

...and the application process

1. Pre-Application Stage (Up to 6 Months Prior to Interview)
    1. Deciding
    2. Identifying Target Firms
    3. Networking
    4. Profile Curation
    5. Fit Preparation
    6. **Case Preparation (qualitative, quantitative, estimation)**
2. Application Stage (Up to 3 Months Prior to Interview)
3. Pre-Interview Stage (Up to 1 Month Prior to Interview)
4. Assessment Centre and/or Interview (T Minus Zero)
5. Post-Interview Stage (Few Days to Few Weeks)

Bright Network; brightnetwork.co.uk/career-path-guides/consulting/eleven-key-skills-consulting-firms-look/

PrepLounge; https://www.preplounge.com/en/articles/guide-to-consulting-recruiting-process

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Cases

Economic Consulting Case Interview

Economic consulting case interviews will give you a taste of what it would be like to be an economic consultant. You'll be placed in a hypothetical business situation and will have 20- to 30-minutes to work with the interviewer to come up with an answer to a broad business problem that relates to economics
Examples of potential business questions you could get asked in an economic consulting case interview include:

- Determining the exact extent of revenue losses caused by a competitor's intellectual property theft of a client's proprietary technology
- Preparing a testimony on behalf of a client to fight litigation against shareholders who are suing the company for neglecting their fiduciary responsibility to keep shareholders appraised of significant changes in business
- Determining how a client should respond to expected political instability in the future

Economic consulting case interviews primarily assess five qualities:

- Logical, structured thinking
- Analytical problem solving
- Business acumen
- Communication skills
- Personality and cultural fit

Link

Qualitative Consulting Case Interview

A qualitative interview is a method of collecting non-numerical data such as how a person thinks or feels about a specific topic through an in-person or phone interview. Qualitative interviews are usually audio recorded to ensure that the data is accurately collected.

For example, in a job interview, a question such as: 'How do you think your previous job experience has prepared you for this position?' would represent a qualitative question.

Qualitative interviews can be interesting, informative and incredibly useful for collecting data. Being open, prepared, and an empathic and attentive listener are key components to successfully leading a qualitative interview.
Link

Estimation Consulting Case Interview

The ability to make reasonable estimates is essential in consulting especially when it comes to market sizing. As such, it is something you are very likely to have to do in your case interview.

Your interviewer might ask something like:

- How many cars are sold in Berlin in one year?
- Our client wants to open a pizza restaurant in Rome. How many pizzas should he expect to sell in his first day of activity?
- How many people will buy the latest high-end smartphone on the market?

Now, there's a small chance you might know the answer to one of these - perhaps you used to live in Germany and worked in the motor industry there. However, the point of such market sizing questions is not to assess your knowledge, but rather to test your reasoning.
When confronted with such questions, the idea is that you should work from what information you do have towards a sensible estimation of the correct value. We can think of estimation as an "educated guess". However, the word "guess" here does not imply plucking an answer purely from the realms of your own imagination. The watchword at every step of estimation is that what you are doing ought to be reasonable. Even if you somehow got close to the real answer, your interviewer will not be impressed if you cannot demonstrate a sensible rationale for how you arrived at it. In fact, your interviewer will very possibly neither know nor care about the real answer - your capacity to reason is all they are interested in..
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The Highway Case

Background

As I am sure you have realised, the Austrian budget situation is in dire straits. With an excessive deficit procedure imminent, the negotiators for the new government are grasping for straws.

You are a wealthy infrastructure developer, currently neither under imminent danger of insolvency nor in prison, and you are well connected with the powers to be. And you get a call… The new Minister of Finance (key positions were agreed very early in the negotiations for a new government) asks you, if you would like to **buy the highway A1** from Vienna to Walserberg near Salzburg for the **bargain price of 2,5 bn Euro**.



Assignment

Case question: At a first glance, is that really a bargain? Since budget negotiations are drawing to a close you have two hours to come up with a Yes or No.

It seems obvious that this is an economic case with a clear cost-benefit rationale. We will see if that is all, but to get started you may assume whatever you like – as long as you can provide a sound rationale for the assumption!

Remember, the quality of a case study not really depends on the outcome but on the way you arrive at an answer, your creativity, your adherence to logical principles and a solid understanding of the economic and financial context.

Structure your group, assign roles and tasks, you have 2 hours, we are here to help if needed. In the end you will present your findings, and we discuss. Take a break when you need it. **Good luck!**

Groups

Group 1 looks at the income stream in detail, what types of revenue, underlying quantity structure, etc. Make rough assumptions for the costs.

Group 2 looks at the cost side of things, what types of costs, underlying trends over the years, etc. Make rough assumptions for revenues.

Since this is an entirely new business for you, **Group 3** looks specifically into the challenges of entering this new market segment, using whatever strategy tools you see fit. We will combine your findings with the results of the other groups.

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